Week 10

Word Classes and Grammatical Categories

internal use only

Grammatical categories

1. Number
2. Gender
3. Person
4. Case
5. Definiteness
6. Degree
7. Tense
8. Aspect
9. Mood
10. Voice

1. Number

- **Singular:** the concept of 'one'

- **Plural**: the concept of 'more than one'

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Number

- Number is expressed by **inflection,** generally by –s

e.g.

- Number is also expressed by **distinct forms** of certain pronouns and adjectives:

e.g.

Number

- Number is also expressed in a limited way in verbs, by the singular –s of the 3rd person which occurs in the present
- Number is also expressed in the inflected form of the verb 'to be'
- **Generic number**: incorporates both singular and plural when one doesn't want to specify number

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2. Gender

- English has a rather straightforward system of gender called **natural gender** (as opposed to grammatical gender).
- Gender is expressed by inflection only in personal pronouns, and only in the 3rd person.
- Gender is generally a covert category shown by the concurrence of relevant pronouns: *the boy …. he, the girl …..she*.

Gender

- Gender may also be expressed overtly in nouns in a number of limited way.
- **By derivational suffixes**: feminine suffixes *–ine,- ess or common gender suffixes –er, -ist, -ard*
- **By compounds:** such as *lady-, woman-, girl-*
- **By separate forms** for masculine, feminine, and common gender: such as boy/girl/child
- **By separate forms** for masculine and feminine genders, such as *uncle/aunt*

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3. Person

- **1st person**: the speaker, person speaking
- **2nd person**: the addressee/hearer, person spoken to
- **3rd person:** the person or thing spoken about.

Person

- Person distinctions are expressed by the inflected forms of the pronouns.

- Personal pronouns

- Personal possessive determiners

- Personal possessive pronouns

- Personal reflexive pronouns

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4. Case

- **Nominative**: I, we, you, he, she, it, they, who
- **Genitive**: my/mine, our/ours, his, her/hers, its, their/theirs, whose.
- **Objective**: me, us, you, him , her, it, them, whom

Case

- Genitive case can be expressed with **'s** or ***of*** **NP**.

The two types are not always possible to substitute each other.

- Double genitive: periphrastic and inflectional forms co-occur. E.g. *a friend of Rosa's*
- The rules for double genitive:
  - The noun with the "of" genitive must be indefinite
  - The noun with the "'s" genitive must be human

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5. Definiteness

- **Definite**: denote a referent which is known, familiar, or identified to the speaker and hearer.
  → Definite article "the".

- **Indefinite**: denotes a referent which is novel, unfamiliar, or not known.
  → Indefinite article "a/an".

Usage of “the”

- For something previously mentioned. (anaphoric referent)
- For a unique or fixed referent
- For a generic referent
- For something which is a part of the immediate socio-physical context or generally known
- For something identified by a modifying expression either preceding or following the noun
- For converting a proper noun to a common

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Usage of “a/an”

- For something mentioned for the first time.
- For something which cannot or need not be identified
- For a generic referent
- Equivalent to ‘any’
- Equivalent to ‘one’
- For converting a proper noun to a common noun

6. Degree

- **Positive degree** expresses a quality
- **Comparative degree** expresses greater degree or intensity of the quality in one of two items.
- **Superlative degree** expresses greatest degree or intensity of the quality in one of three or more items.

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Degree

- **Positive**: root of the adjective or adverb
- **Comparative**: *-er, more*
- **Superlative**: *-est, most*
- Note: For semantic reason, not all adjectives can be inflected for degree.

7. Tense

- Linguistic indication of the time of an action.
- It expresses a relation: the time of an event **in respect to** the moment of speaking.
- The only tense distinction expressed inflectionally is that between present and past.
- The future is expressed ***periphrastically***.

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Tense

- **Present tense expressed:**

- *Habits:* we eat dinner at 6:00
- *States*: I like chocolate. I believe you.
- *Generic statement*: Beavers build dams.
- *Timeless statements*: the sun sets in the west.
- *Proverbial statements*: Haste makes waste.

Tense

- *Future statements*: We leave tomorrow.
- *Instantaneous commentary*: He shoots. He scores.
- *Plot summary*: Hamlet dies at the end of the play.
- *Narration in the present*: Then he says …
- *Information present*: I hear/see that Manfred has been promoted.

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Tense

- **Past tense:**

- Denotes an event or a state in past time:
- Denote a past habit
- Denote non-temporally for politeness to denote present or the future
- Denote the future or unreal in hypothetical statements

Tense

- **Future tense:** express non-inflectionally by:

- will/shall + infinitive
- The simple present
- The present progressive
- Be going to, be about to + infinitive
- Shall/ will + the progressive

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8. Aspect

- Perfective and progressive.
- **The progressive:** be + present participle, presents action as in progress, ongoing, and incomplete
- It denotes:

- A continuous activity
- A repeated activity
- A process leading up to an endpoint

Aspect

- **The perfect:** have + the past participle, presents the 'current relevance' of past tense.

- The past tense is relevant either by its continuation to the present of by its results in the present.

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Aspect

- *Continuative :*

- I have lived here since childhood.
- She has sung in the choir for 10 years.

- *Resultative:*

- She has recovered from the flu.
- I have read the novel.

9. Mood

- An indication of the speaker's attitude towards what he or she is talking about, i.e. fact (indicative) or non-fact (subjunctive , imperative).

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Mood

- **Indicative:** is expressed by the simple form of the verb.

- **Subjunctive:** remnant forms
- the lack of –s for 3rd person
- *be* for all persons
- number of the present tense
- *were* for the past tense

Mood

- **Subjunctive in main clause**: highly formulaic e.g. *God save the Queen; Have mercy on us*.
- **Subjunctive in dependent clauses:**

- *That*-clauses following ***verbs*** such as *insist, suggest, recommend, beg, ask, be required*; ***adjectives*** such as *advisable, imperative, desirable*; and nouns such as *decision, requirement, resolution.*
- *If clause: if she had time,…; if we were rich, ….*
- Clause following verbs of wishing: *I wish I were rich*.

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Mood

- **Imperative:** a subclass of subjunctive which expresses direct commands.
- It is the subjectless sentence containing a bare form of the verb.

10. Voice

- Active voice: the subject is performing action if he verb or being something.
- Passive voice : the subject is being affected by the action or being acted upon.

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Voice

- Active voice: expressed by simple forms of the verb.
- Passive voice: expressed by:

- *Get* + the past participle.
- *Be* + the past participle.